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GEHLOT HAS A FEW ADVANTAGES: AN OBC LEADER WHO ROSE THROUGH THE RANKS, HE WILL BE A STRONG REPLY TO CRITICISM

through that kind of situation before. After Rajiv Gandhi's death in 1991, when Sonia was reluctant to join politics, P.V. Narasimha Rao became the prime minister as well as the Congress president. The Gandhis backed him in the belief that he was a retired politician without much clout. Soon, however, Rao started displaying a mind of his own and proved to be a shrewd manoeuverer who knew how to elude their control entirely and chart his own path—even if the party did not exactly stay in robust health in that phase.

His successor, Sitaram Kesri, too, wasn't amenable to taking orders and displayed all signs of going for full autonomy before being shunted out in a coup where Sonia formally took charge of the party.

IF NOT A GANDHI, WHO?

That was a phase that reflected two realities. One, given a chance, a non-Gandhi leadership is eminently possible—there is no dearth of either talent or ambition. Two, that does not automatically entail the best results for the party. Sonia's arrival at the helm had restored a sense of order and coherence that had been missing.

This time, the first family is being careful about who takes charge in their absence. Reports have it that Sonia has requested Rajasthan CM Ashok Gehlot to contest, but the 71-year-old leader is reluctant. Congress sources claim he has placed two conditions for accepting the job—either he be allowed to continue as Rajasthan CM or pick someone of his choice as his successor. While there has been no confirmation from either Gehlot or Sonia, fulfilling either of the conditions will not be easy. For one, the Udaipur resolution of the Congress in May proposed a 'one person, one post' policy. His second condition is aimed at denying bête noire and former deputy CM Sachin Pilot any opening. No official confirmation exists, but insiders claim the Gandhi siblings had worked out a compromise deal with Sachin to mollify him when he threatened to follow Jyotiraditya Scindia's path of rebellion in 2020: that the chief ministership of Rajasthan would be his a year before the state goes to polls in 2023. The Gehlot gambit fits in with that.

That apart, the Rajasthan CM ticks almost all the boxes for a Congress president. He is a prominent leader from the north, where the party has performed abysmally in the past two Lok Sabha polls. He has been a former Union minister, is a three-time chief minister and is nifty with organisation-building. As then general secretary (organisation), he was also instrumental in the party's superlative performance in the assembly polls in Gujarat in 2017—where they ran the BJP close in Modi's home state. (He will be the party's election observer for Gujarat later this year.) Also, vitally, he is an OBC leader, just like PM Modi, and is someone who rose through the ranks. While almost all parties have been trying to woo the OBC vote bank, a swing factor in any election, the most potent criticism against the Congress is its obsession with the Gandhi dynasty. Gehlot as Congress president will be a strong counter to those who accuse the Congress of being a one-family party, and also bring it in sync with the OBC axis around which a common anti-BJP politics might turn in the run-up to 2024, driven by themes like a caste census. Here, the Congress needs to build alliances with Opposition parties. While Sonia has taken a back seat, several Opposition leaders are not comfortable with Rahul's working style. Gehlot, by contrast, shares a warm equation with most Opposition leaders. Even within the Congress, the Rajasthan CM maintains a cordial relationship with the G23 leaders, making him more acceptable than others. All this, while also enjoying the trust of the family.

Names like Mallikarjun Kharge, Meira Kumar and Mukul Wasnik are doing the rounds too, but Gehlot has an edge because of his access to business leaders. The Congress has been facing a resource crunch and the Rajasthan CM could use his contacts in the corporate world to generate funds. "It's unlikely he can say no if the Gandhi family firmly tells him to do so. The Gandhis would not bother much about Pilot if he has to be sacrificed to make Gehlot fall in line," says a Rajya Sabha MP.

Irrespective of which non-Gandhi puts his or her hand up, there will be a contest, unlike in 2017, when Rahul was the only one in the fray. The last time the Congress saw a presidential election was in 2001 when Jitendra Prasada fought against Sonia. Of the 7,542 valid votes, he polled only 94. While the Gandhi-backed candidate will have an advantage, there is speculation that Shashi Tharoor, three-time Lok Sabha MP and one of the G23 leaders, may throw his hat in the ring. Tharoor declined to comment, but some leaders say he has been trying to "galvanise a discussion" around the need to have a fair election process. "I hope several candidates come forward to present themselves for consideration. Putting forward their visions for the party and the nation will surely stir public interest," Tharoor wrote in a newspaper article on August 29.

What's certain is that the Congress will have a new president by October 17. "Irrespective of who heads the party, it will remain one united family and the pivot of the Opposition," says Singhvi. That's ambitious for a party that has repeatedly fallen back on the Gandhi surname to avoid disintegration. ■